The Age of Totalitarianisms

In Ottoman-ruled south-east Europe, the nineteenth century was marked by uprisings against the Turkish overlords. Greeks started rebelling in 1821 and finally succeeded in gaining their independence a few years later. The liberation movement started in Bulgaria at about the same time. Nationhood was won in the late 1870s in at least part of the country but full independence was achieved only at the beginning of the twentieth century. The timeframe was similar for Serbia. The principalities of Wallachia and Moldavia were united under the name of Romania in the mid-nineteenth century. A modernisation of Romanian society, previously under Ottoman and Russian rule, commenced and full independence from the Ottomans was achieved in 1877. Indeed, this was a landmark year for all the countries of south-east Europe because of Russia's victory over the Ottoman Empire which helped them in their own fight for independence – something about which Russians will have reminded these nations even during the recent aggression against Ukraine a century and a half later.

In Central Europe too, as we saw earlier, the nineteenth century was a time of nationalist revival, echoing the general mood in the rest of Europe. Germany and Italy were created at much the same time – both are relatively young nation-states too! While in south-east Europe the national movements were directed against the Ottomans, in Central Europe the main adversaries were the Germans and the Austrians. A revolutionary spirit spread among the Slavic nations within the Austro-Hungarian Empire (and Prussia) and, as has already been mentioned in the previous chapter, a cultural struggle began. This struggle was also reflected in the arts of Eastern European countries of the time. As Stephen Mansbach has written, 'As a consequence of the nineteenth- and twentieth-century limitations on the free exercise of political, economic, and personal liberties in the regions of the Continent subject to Romanov, Hohenzollern, Habsburg, and Ottoman control, the visual arts assumed a primary responsibility as cultural custodian for the respective "subject nations". Hence, artists of these regions often elected to emphasise national individuality rather than universality. They responded variously to a public demand for expressions